

Animal species

Scientists have identified about two million kinds, or species, of animal. They are classified into about 30 major groups, called phyla. Toucans belong to the chordate phylum—a group containing all animals that have skeletons made of bone. All toucans have a similar body shape and huge bills. They look similar because they have evolved from the same distant ancestor. However, each species has its own color pattern and usually breeds only with its own kind. If toucan species interbred, their differences would blend away.



The toco toucan is the largest toucan. Unlike other toucans, it prefers open habitats with scattered trees.



The white-throated toucan is the second-largest species. It is widespread in South America's rain forests.



The channel-billed toucan differs only in slight details from the white-throated toucan. It also lives in the rain forests of South America.



The choco toucan lives in forests in western South America, where it is cut off from most other toucans by the high Andes mountains.



Animal adaptations

Leaning forward from a branch, a panther chameleon grabs a cricket with its telescopic tongue. Chameleons are lizards, but unlike most lizards, they have many features well-suited to their life in trees. Features like these are called adaptations. They develop through evolution and can affect how animals look, their behavior, and the way their bodies work. Some adaptations have proved to be a runaway success. These breakthroughs include skeletons made of bone, which first evolved more than 450 million years ago, and insect wings, which date back nearly as far. They have helped to make vertebrates and insects two of the most successful animal groups on Earth.



New World monkeys



Old World monkeys



Gibbons



Great apes and humans

- Mobile face with lips that can protrude
- Single pair of nipples on chest

- Two premolar teeth
- Nostrils close together
- All fingers and toes with nails, not claws

- Highly mobile shoulder joints
- Can move for limited periods when standing on hind legs

- Skeleton suited to upright or semi-upright stance
- Highly enlarged brain

Long, sucker-tipped tongue can catch food on neighboring twigs

Cricket is too slow to evade tongue attack

